

ARTHUR

(With intense emotion, but restrained)

Proposition: If I could choose, from every woman who breathes on this earth, the face I would most love, the smile, the touch, the voice, the heart, the laugh, the soul itself, every detail and feature to the smallest strand of hair—they would all be Jenny's.

(HE takes a step forward)

Proposition: If I could choose, from every man who breathes on this earth, a man for my brother and a man for my son, a man for my friend, they would all be Lance.

(HE steps forward. Then, with mounting bitterness)

Yes, I love them. I love them, and they answer me again with pain and torment. Be it sin or not sin, they betray me in their hearts, and that's far sin enough. I see it in their eyes and feel it when they speak, and they must pay for it and be punished. I shan't be wounded and not return it in kind. I'm done with feeble hoping. I demand a man's vengeance!

(HE steps forward violently, then stops, controlling himself. HE takes a few thoughtful steps across the stage, then stops. When he continues, it's with a touch of confusion and almost boyish innocence)

Proposition: I'm a king, not a man. And a civilized king. Could it possibly be civilized to destroy what I love? Could it possibly be civilized to love myself above all?

(HE takes a hesitant step forward)

What of their pain and their torment? Did they ask for this calamity? Can passion be selected?

(His voice rising)

Is there any doubt of their devotion... to me, or to our Table?

(HE pauses again, then slowly walks to the throne and takes the Sword in his hand. With exultant defiance)

By God, Excalibur, I shall be a King! This is the time of King Arthur, and we reach for the stars! This is the time of King Arthur, and violence is not strength and compassion is not weakness. We are civilized! Resolved: We shall live through this together, Excalibur... they... you... and I... And God have mercy on us all.

(The decision made, HE becomes almost relaxed, almost at peace)

They're waiting for us at the Table.

(HE starts to walk off)

Let's not delay the celebration.

(The MUSIC swells, and the CURTAIN descends for the...)

END OF ACT ONE

additional reading, pg 1

(GUENEVERE)

MY LOVE, FAR AWAY,
TILL I FORGET I GAZED AT YOU TODAY...
TODAY... TODAY... TODAY.

*(The LIGHTS DIM SLOWLY for the end of Scene Nine)**(LANCELOT enters. GUENEVERE doesn't see him at first)***Start
Here**

LANCELOT

Forgive me, Milady. I didn't mean to disturb you, but I was told that Arthur wanted to see me.

GUENEVERE

(As casually as she can)

I believe he does. And you're not disturbing me at all. You are to be knighted.

LANCELOT

(Troubled)

When, Milady?

GUENEVERE

This evening.

LANCELOT

I wish he would not.

GUENEVERE

Why?

LANCELOT

I'm not worthy of it, Milady. I don't deserve it.

GUENEVERE

Not deserve it, Lancelot! What greater wonder could you ever perform? Oh, no, I'm sure Arthur will insist. Now, if you'll excuse me, I must change for dinner.

(SHE starts to leave)

Do wait here. Arthur will be...

LANCELOT

(Quietly)

Jenny, don't go.

(SHE pauses, hearing him say her name for the first time, almost knowing what he is about to say)

Jenny, I love you. God forgive me, but I do.

GUENEVERE & LANCELOT
additional reading, pg 2

GUENEVERE

(Without turning)

God forgive us both, Lance.

LANCELOT

I have known it since the first afternoon. Not when we met; but when I walked away. When...

(GUENEVERE turns to him, as ARTHUR enters. When he does, SHE turns away again)

ARTHUR

Lance! What a stunning achievement, my boy! And the Court! You could almost hear everyone's heart break open to you.

(Good-humoredly)

Surely I may arrange for your knighthood now. Unfortunately, sainthood is not in my power.

LANCELOT

**End
Here**

I shall be honored, Arthur.

ARTHUR

Before we throw ourselves into pomp and ritual, I think we three should have a quiet drink together. If you'll make an exception, Lance.

(HE turns to the decanter and starts to pour the first glass)

Do you have any idea the impact the miracle will have on the country?

(LANCELOT and GUENEVERE turn slowly towards each other as he pours, until their eyes meet. THEY take a step towards each other. ARTHUR turns back with one glass filled, and sees their look. HE continues talking, looking from one to the other, feverishly – painfully)

When this is known, they'll be flocking to the Round Table from one end of England to the other... from Scotland... Wales... and all those quests we've been planning for the knights may not even be necessary... I mean, when people hear... what has happened at Camelot... they may lay down their arms and come of their own free will... it's quite possible no one will bear arms at all anymore... and that there will really be peace... all borders will disappear... and all the things I dreamed...

I dreamed... I dreamed...

(HIS VOICE trails off in utter defeat, and HE stands motionless in an abject trance.)

The sound of the MARCH TO THE GRAND HALL is heard in the ORCHESTRA, as the LIGHTS DIM OUT SLOWLY)

DINADAN

(Announces)

Sound the trumpet! We shall greet Lady Guenevere at the foot of the hill in the traditional fashion.

#2 – March

(The LADIES and GENTLEMEN assemble formally and, with banners flying, parade across the stage and off, followed by others who were obviously waiting offstage. Appropriate MUSIC accompanies them. When the stage is clear, MERLYN pauses before the tree and, without looking up at it, speaks:)

MERLYN

Arthur, come down out of the tree.

(There is no response)

Your Majesty, I know you're up there. Come down at once.

(There is no response)

Wart, come down at once! You're perfectly safe. There's no one here.

(KING ARTHUR peers out of the tree)

ARTHUR

Why so angry, Merlyn? I know you are because you called me Wart.

MERLYN

Yes, Wart. Your schoolboy's nickname. That's what your behavior warrants. Perched in a tree trying to steal a look at your bride. Will you never learn patience?

(ARTHUR climbs down)

ARTHUR

I'm the King – others must learn patience.

(He returns to MERLYN, with boyish enthusiasm)

How is she, Merlyn? Is she beautiful?

MERLYN

(Still piqued)

I don't recall.

ARTHUR

Rubbish. Are you pretending you don't see into the future?

MERLYN

When you live backwards in time as I do, and have the future to remember as well as the past, occasionally you do forget a face.

ARTHUR

MERLYN page 2

(Dictatorially)

Merlyn, as your King, I command you to tell me if she...

MERLYN

(Irritated to make the revelation)

She's beautiful.

ARTHUR

(Suddenly almost frightened)

Quite, or very?

MERLYN

Very.

ARTHUR

(Frustrated by his own discomfort)

Merlyn, why have you never taught me love and marriage?

MERLYN

Don't scramble them together that way. They are two different things. Besides, I did give you a lesson once, but your mind was, as usual, elsewhere. You had better heed me well from now on. I shan't be here long.

ARTHUR

Why not?

MERLYN

I've told you, I'm due to be bewitched by a nymph named Nimue, who will steal my magic powers and lock me in a cave for several centuries.

ARTHUR

Nimue—fiddlesticks! Whenever you're displeased with me, you threaten me with this creature Nimue.

MERLYN

It's not a threat; it will happen.

ARTHUR

When you know she is near, change yourself into a bat.

MERLYN

One cannot escape fate. She would come as a female bat.

ARTHUR

(At his most youthful and charming)

Merlyn, do you remember when I was a boy and you changed me into a hawk?

(ARTHUR)

What a feeling, sailing through the air! For old times' sake, do it again. Right this minute. One last soar through the sky.

MERLYN

So you can soar through the sky to her carriage and see her through the window?
No.

ARTHUR

(Furious)

Merlyn, there are times when I insist that you remember who I am. You will do as I tell you. Make me a hawk, or I'll have your head cut off.

MERLYN

It's you who keep forgetting who you are. Think of the joy you've brought to Camelot. A radiant young princess never before out of her castle, come by treaty to bring peace between peoples. A royal marriage. A new queen. And where is the King? Swinging in the trees. Thank heaven history never knew. Thank heaven Mallory and Tennyson never found out. Thank heaven your people are not aware of your behavior. Now go back to the castle. At once.

(HE exits)

ARTHUR

My people indeed! As if they give a thought to what I'm doing tonight.

(Defiantly)

Oh, good and loyal subjects of the Crown, are you really peering up at the castle with a question mark in each eye, throbbing with curiosity about the King's humor on his pre-nuptial night?

(Defeatedly)

Yes, you are. That's precisely what you are doing. Every last blessed one of you.

#3 – I Wonder What The King Is Doing Tonight

(Singing)

I KNOW WHAT MY PEOPLE ARE THINKING TONIGHT,
AS HOME THROUGH THE SHADOWS THEY WANDER.
EV'RYONE SMILING IN SECRET DELIGHT,
THEY STARE AT THE CASTLE AND PONDER.
WHENEVER THE WIND BLOWS THIS WAY,
YOU CAN ALMOST HEAR EV'RYONE SAY:

I WONDER WHAT THE KING IS DOING TONIGHT.